

THE GIFT OF THE MAGI

SHOWCASES:
INTEGRATED
SKILLS DESIGN,
PAIRED READING
DESIGN, LITERARY
SCAFFOLDING

AT A GLANCE:

- SKILLS-BASED LESSON
 - 12TH GRADE LITERATURE
 - 120-MINUTE LESSON (OR 2 X 60 MIN)
 - PAIR WORK
-

MATERIALS:

- STUDENT FACING WORKSHEET (6 PGS PDF)
 - READING CHUNK HANDOUT (5 PGS)
 - TEACHER GUIDE (6 PGS)
 - CREDITS AND ATTRIBUTIONS (1 PG)
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OBJECTIVES:

BY THE END OF THIS LESSON, STUDENTS WILL BE ABLE TO

- **USE** CONTEXT CLUES TO FIGURE OUT THE MEANING OF TRICKY WORDS AND PHRASES FROM THE STORY.
 - **EXPLAIN** HOW THE SURPRISE ENDING OF "THE GIFT OF THE MAGI" MADE THEM FEEL.
 - **EVALUATE** WHETHER THE CHARACTERS IN THE STORY HANDLED THE SITUATION WELL AT THE END.
 - **COMPOSE** A BRIEF REFLECTION ABOUT A MEANINGFUL GIFT-EXCHANGE EXPERIENCE FROM THEIR OWN LIFE.
 - **COMPARE AND CONTRAST** THEIR GIFT-GIVING EXPERIENCE WITH A PARTNER'S AND WITH THE STORY, USING WORDS LIKE "SIMILARLY," "IN CONTRAST," AND "UNLIKE."
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The Gift of the Magi | Skills-Based Worksheet

Student Version | Grade 12 | High School Literature | 120-Minute Lesson | Pair Work

Objectives

By the end of this lesson, I'll be able to:

1. use context clues to figure out the meaning of tricky words and phrases from the story.
2. explain how the surprise ending of "The Gift of the Magi" made me feel.
3. evaluate whether the characters in the story handled the situation well at the end.
4. compose a brief reflection about a meaningful gift-exchange experience from my own life.
5. compare and contrast my gift-giving experience with my partner's and with the story, using words like "similarly," "in contrast," and "unlike."

Warm Up: Guess the Meaning

Let's warm up with some tricky words and phrases you'll see during the reading activity. With your partner, review each sentence, then circle the option (A or B) you think best matches the meaning of the bolded word/phrase.

1. "Meretricious"

"...it was 'made light of,' as most of our great deeds are, and not proclaiming its value by meretricious ornamentation."

A) Cheap-looking or fake, despite trying to appear attractive

B) Expensive and truly beautiful

2. "Beggar description"

"It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad."

A) Impossible to fully describe because it's so extreme or unusual

B) So poor and shabby that it looks embarrassing

3. "Flung to the breeze"

"The 'Dillingham' had been flung to the breeze during a former period of prosperity..."

A) Thrown away and forgotten

B) Shown off publicly, used proudly and openly

4. "Mammoth task"



“One dollar and eighty-seven cents to buy a present for Jim... And then she had a mammoth task before her: finding the perfect gift.”

- A) A huge, difficult undertaking
- B) A task involving large animals

5. “The Magi”

“The magi, as you know, were wise men — wonderfully wise men — who brought gifts to the Babe in the manger.”

- A) Wise travelers from an old story, famous for giving thoughtful gifts
- B) A group of magicians who performed tricks for royalty

6. “Parsimony”

“...bulldozing the grocer and the vegetable man and the butcher until one’s cheeks burned with the silent imputation of parsimony that such close dealing implied.”

- A) Stinginess; being overly careful or cheap with money
- B) Generosity; giving away too much money

7. “Instigates the moral reflection”

“Which instigates the moral reflection that life is made up of sobs, sniffles, and smiles, with sniffles predominating.”

- A) This leads you to think seriously about a lesson or truth
- B) This makes you angry enough to complain to someone

8. “Longitudinal strips”

“A very thin and agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks.”

- A) Long, narrow vertical sections, like slices
- B) Wide, horizontal bands across the middle

Let’s Learn: Compare VS Contrast

The images below show that we each have a set of gifts. My set includes a yellow and red gift. Yours also includes a yellow and red gift. However, your set has an additional purple and green gift.



My Set of Gifts



Your Set of Gifts



To explain the similarities and differences between our two sets of gifts, we can use compare and contrast connectors such as: **similarly, in contrast, unlike, on the other hand, and likewise.**

Language that showcases **similarities** | **similarly** and **likewise**

- Example: My set includes a yellow and red gift. **Similarly**, your set also includes a yellow and red gift.

Language that showcases **differences** | **unlike, on the other hand** and **in contrast**

- Example: **Unlike** my set that only has gifts with two colors, yours has gifts with five colors.

Practice Time: Complete the Sentences

Based on the sets of gifts we reviewed in the previous section, complete the following sentences by circling the best option in bold on your own. If you're not sure, please ask your partner or teacher.

1. I have two types of colored gifts. **On the other hand / Similarly**, you have five types of colored gifts.
2. I have a yellow and red gift in my set. **Likewise / Unlike**, you have a yellow and red gift in your set.
3. I only have a yellow and red gift in my set. This is **in contrast / similarly** to your set, which also includes a green and a purple gift.

Your Turn: Create Sentences with Your Partner

Work with your partner to create two sentences that use the compare and contrast connectors you just learned. They can be about gifts or any other topic you're interested in.

1st sentence that showcases a similarity: _____



2nd sentence that showcases a difference: _____

Reading: The Gift of the Magi

You'll be reading the short story 'The Gift of the Magi' by O. Henry (*written in 1905, in the public domain*) with your partner.

- Your teacher will provide you with a hard copy of the story that has been chunked for 2 students.
- Determine who will be 'Student A' and 'Student B.'
- Take turns reading each chunk.
- Pause at the end of each turn to note any new vocabulary or key concepts (outside of the ones learned in the 1st section).
- Uncertain about the meaning of a word? Use a dictionary to look up the definition and discuss it together before moving on.

💡 *As you're reading the last paragraph, jot down a few words or a sentence about how you feel when you reach the ending and how the characters reacted.*



Reflection: The twist ending and your own story

Part I: On your own, write two paragraphs. The 1st should be focused on the story and the 2nd, a reflection on your own gift-exchange experiences. Use the questions in the table below to guide you along.

1 st Paragraph Thoughts on the story's ending	2 nd Paragraph Compose a reflection about a meaningful gift-exchange experience
How did the ending of the story make you feel?	What was exchanged and why (holiday, birthday, etc.)?
Were you surprised or did you see it coming?	What did you feel when you received your gift?
Do you think the characters handled the situation well? If not, what could they have done better?	How did the other person react?
	Did you think that it was all worth it in the end? Why?

My Response



Exchanging Stories: Sharing our Experiences

Part II: You and your partner will verbally share:

1. Your thoughts about the story's ending.
2. Your own experiences related to gift exchanges.

Write down notes as you listen.

Exchanging Stories: Comparing our Experiences

Part III: Last exercise is for you and your partner to compare and contrast both of your experiences with the characters' gift-exchange experience.

Were there any similarities? Or, perhaps the situations and feelings were completely different. Please use your voices to work with one another, and to include the finalized sentences (try to reach for 3 to 5) in the space below.

 *Language Bank | Use the compare and contrast connectors you learned earlier in the lesson: **similarly, in contrast, unlike, on the other hand and likewise.***

Comparing Our Experiences



The Gift of the Magi | Paired Reading Chunks

'The Gift of the Magi' by O. Henry (*written in 1905, in the public domain*)

Instructions: Take turns reading aloud with your partner. Student A reads the "Student A" chunks; Student B reads the "Student B" chunks. Follow the numbers in order to keep the story flowing.

Chunk 1 — Student A

One dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all. And sixty cents of it was in pennies. Pennies saved one and two at a time by bulldozing the grocer and the vegetable man and the butcher until one's cheeks burned with the silent imputation of parsimony that such close dealing implied. Three times Della counted it. One dollar and eighty-seven cents. And the next day would be Christmas. There was clearly nothing to do but flop down on the shabby little couch and howl. So Della did it. Which instigates the moral reflection that life is made up of sobs, sniffles, and smiles, with sniffles predominating. While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at \$8 per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad. In the vestibule below was a letter-box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring. Also appertaining thereunto was a card bearing the name "Mr. James Dillingham Young."

Chunk 2 — Student B

The "Dillingham" had been flung to the breeze during a former period of prosperity when its possessor was being paid \$30 per week. Now, when the income was shrunk to \$20, though, they were thinking seriously of contracting to a modest and unassuming D. But whenever Mr. James Dillingham Young came home and reached his flat above he was called "Jim" and greatly hugged by Mrs. James Dillingham Young, already introduced to you as Della. Which is all very good. Della finished her cry and attended to her cheeks with the powder rag. She stood by the window and looked out dully at a gray cat walking a gray fence in a gray backyard. Tomorrow would be Christmas Day, and she had only \$1.87 with which to buy Jim a present. She had been saving every penny she could for months, with this result. Twenty dollars a week doesn't go far. Expenses had been greater than she had calculated. They always are. Only \$1.87 to buy a present for Jim. Her Jim. Many a happy hour she had spent planning for something nice for him. Something fine and rare and sterling—something just a little bit near to being worthy of the honor of being owned by Jim.



Chunk 3 — Student A

There was a pier glass between the windows of the room. Perhaps you have seen a pier glass in an \$8 flat. A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks. Della, being slender, had mastered the art. Suddenly she whirled from the window and stood before the glass. Her eyes were shining brilliantly, but her face had lost its color within twenty seconds. Rapidly she pulled down her hair and let it fall to its full length. Now, there were two possessions of the James Dillingham Youngs in which they both took a mighty pride. One was Jim's gold watch that had been his father's and his grandfather's. The other was Della's hair. Had the queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the airshaft, Della would have let her hair hang out the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts. Had King Solomon been the janitor, with all his treasures piled up in the basement, Jim would have pulled out his watch every time he passed, just to see him pluck at his beard from envy.

Chunk 4 — Student B

So now Della's beautiful hair fell about her rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters. It reached below her knee and made itself almost a garment for her. And then she did it up again nervously and quickly. Once she faltered for a minute and stood still while a tear or two splashed on the worn red carpet. On went her old brown jacket; on went her old brown hat. With a whirl of skirts and with the brilliant sparkle still in her eyes, she fluttered out the door and down the stairs to the street. Where she stopped the sign read: "Mme. Sofronie. Hair Goods of All Kinds." One flight up Della ran, and collected herself, panting. Madame, large, too white, chilly, hardly looked the "Sofronie." "Will you buy my hair?" asked Della. "I buy hair," said Madame. "Take yer hat off and let's have a sight at the looks of it." Down rippled the brown cascade. "Twenty dollars," said Madame, lifting the mass with a practised hand. "Give it to me quick," said Della.

Chunk 5 — Student A

Oh, and the next two hours tripped by on rosy wings. Forget the hashed metaphor. She was ransacking the stores for Jim's present. She found it at last. It surely had been made for Jim and no one else. There was no other like it in any of the stores, and she had turned all of them inside out. It was a platinum fob chain simple and chaste in design, properly proclaiming its value by substance alone and not by meretricious ornamentation—as all good things should do. It was even worthy of The Watch. As soon as she saw it she knew that it must be Jim's. It was like him. Quietness and value—the description applied to both. Twenty-one dollars they took from her for it, and she hurried home with the 87 cents. With that chain on his watch Jim might be properly anxious about the time in any company. Grand as the watch was, he sometimes looked at it on the sly on account of the old leather strap that he used in place of a chain.



Chunk 6 — Student B

When Della reached home her intoxication gave way a little to prudence and reason. She got out her curling irons and lighted the gas and went to work repairing the ravages made by generosity added to love. Which is always a tremendous task, dear friends—a mammoth task. Within forty minutes her head was covered with tiny, close-lying curls that made her look wonderfully like a truant schoolboy. She looked at her reflection in the mirror long, carefully, and critically. "If Jim doesn't kill me," she said to herself, "before he takes a second look at me, he'll say I look like a Coney Island chorus girl. But what could I do—oh! what could I do with a dollar and eighty-seven cents?" At 7 o'clock the coffee was made and the frying-pan was on the back of the stove hot and ready to cook the chops. Jim was never late. Della doubled the fob chain in her hand and sat on the corner of the table near the door that he always entered. Then she heard his step on the stair away down on the first flight, and she turned white for just a moment. She had a habit of saying a little silent prayer about the simplest everyday things, and now she whispered: "Please God, make him think I am still pretty."

Chunk 7 — Student A

The door opened and Jim stepped in and closed it. He looked thin and very serious. Poor fellow, he was only twenty-two—and to be burdened with a family! He needed a new overcoat and he was without gloves. Jim stopped inside the door, as immovable as a setter at the scent of quail. His eyes were fixed upon Della, and there was an expression in them that she could not read, and it terrified her. It was not anger, nor surprise, nor disapproval, nor horror, nor any of the sentiments that she had been prepared for. He simply stared at her fixedly with that peculiar expression on his face. Della wriggled off the table and went for him. "Jim, darling," she cried, "don't look at me that way. I had my hair cut off and sold because I couldn't have lived through Christmas without giving you a present. It'll grow out again—you won't mind, will you? I just had to do it. My hair grows awfully fast. Say 'Merry Christmas!' Jim, and let's be happy. You don't know what a nice—what a beautiful, nice gift I've got for you."

Chunk 8 — Student B

"You've cut off your hair?" asked Jim, laboriously, as if he had not arrived at that patent fact yet even after the hardest mental labor. "Cut it off and sold it," said Della. "Don't you like me just as well, anyhow? I'm me without my hair, ain't I?" Jim looked about the room curiously. "You say your hair is gone?" he said, with an air almost of idiocy. "You needn't look for it," said Della. "It's sold, I tell you—sold and gone, too. It's Christmas Eve, boy. Be good to me, for it went for you. Maybe the hairs of my head were numbered," she went on with sudden serious sweetness, "but nobody could ever count my love for you. Shall I put the chops on, Jim?" Out of his trance Jim seemed quickly to wake. He enfolded his Della. For ten seconds let us regard with discreet scrutiny some inconsequential object in the other direction. Eight dollars a week or a million a



year—what is the difference? A mathematician or a wit would give you the wrong answer. The magi brought valuable gifts, but that was not among them. This dark assertion will be illuminated later on.

Chunk 9 — Student A

Jim drew a package from his overcoat pocket and threw it upon the table. "Don't make any mistake, Dell," he said, "about me. I don't think there's anything in the way of a haircut or a shave or a shampoo that could make me like my girl any less. But if you'll unwrap that package you may see why you had me going a while at first." White fingers and nimble tore at the string and paper. And then an ecstatic scream of joy; and then, alas! a quick feminine change to hysterical tears and wails, necessitating the immediate employment of all the comforting powers of the lord of the flat. For there lay The Combs—the set of combs, side and back, that Della had worshipped long in a Broadway window. Beautiful combs, pure tortoise shell, with jewelled rims—just the shade to wear in the beautiful vanished hair. They were expensive combs, she knew, and her heart had simply craved and yearned over them without the least hope of possession. And now, they were hers, but the tresses that should have adorned the coveted adornments were gone.

Chunk 10 — Student B

But she hugged them to her bosom, and at length she was able to look up with dim eyes and a smile and say: "My hair grows so fast, Jim!" And then Della leaped up like a little singed cat and cried, "Oh, oh!" Jim had not yet seen his beautiful present. She held it out to him eagerly upon her open palm. The dull precious metal seemed to flash with a reflection of her bright and ardent spirit. "Isn't it a dandy, Jim? I hunted all over town to find it. You'll have to look at the time a hundred times a day now. Give me your watch. I want to see how it looks on it." Instead of obeying, Jim tumbled down on the couch and put his hands under the back of his head and smiled. "Dell," said he, "let's put our Christmas presents away and keep 'em a while. They're too nice to use just at present. I sold the watch to get the money to buy your combs. And now suppose you put the chops on."

Chunk 11 — Student A

The magi, as you know, were wise men—wonderfully wise men—who brought gifts to the Babe in the manger. They invented the art of giving Christmas presents. Being wise, their gifts were no doubt wise ones, possibly bearing the privilege of exchange in case of duplication. And here I have lamely related to you the uneventful chronicle of two foolish children in a flat who most unwisely sacrificed for each other the greatest treasures of their house. But in a last word to the wise of these days let it be said that of all who give gifts these two were the wisest. Of all who give and receive gifts, such as they are wisest. Everywhere they are wisest. They are the magi.



The Gift of the Magi | Skills-Based Worksheet

Teacher's Guide

Grade 12 | High School Literature | 120-Minute Lesson | Pair Work

Materials Needed:

- **Student:** Worksheet, 'The Gift of the Magi' chunked PDF, dictionary, pen/pencil, simple timer (per pair).
- **Teacher:** Whiteboard, blown up images of gifts from pg. 3 of worksheet.

Grouping: Assign students into pairs. You will be walking around the room to monitor time, provide guidance and answer questions.

Methodology Note: The reading lesson starts with a classic warmer (vocabulary) and then focuses on a short ESA flow that looks at compare and contrast language. It then boomerangs back to the main content (story) and ends with reflection questions.

Timing Note: This lesson is suitable for a full 120 min lesson block or 2 x 60 min lessons.

Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
Objectives (5 min)	Encourage students to read objectives with their partners. Encourage them to ask you if there are any questions.	—	—	Provide students with: 1. lesson road map. 2. space for questions about expectations.
Warm-Up Engage Section 15 min				
Guess the Meaning (8 vocabulary items)	Suggest that students read through the vocabulary and context sentences together. Each should choose their own	If students are struggling to agree on the correct answer, they can use their dictionaries and/or	1) A 2) A 3) B 4) A 5) A 6) A 7) A 8) A	Provide students with: 1. familiarity of a few of the more challenging words they'll be exposed



Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
	answer and come to an agreement. So that everyone remains on track, include the answers on the board at the 9 min mark and have everyone check their work.	ask you for guidance.		to in the reading exercise. 2. a preview of parts of the story through the context sentences. <i>Objective focus:</i> #1. use context clues to figure out the meaning of tricky words and phrases from the story.
Language Focus Study Section 20 min				
Let's Learn: Compare vs. Contrast (10 min)	This will be the only 'teacher-centered' part of the lesson. You will have either actual gifts on your desk or paper cut-outs that mimic what is included in the worksheet under 'My Set of Gifts' and 'Your Set of Gifts.' Ask students to chorally recite the compare and contrast words after you. Read through the example sentences.	—	—	Structured presentation of the new language that'll be heavily used in students' reflection activities. It's also a foundational precursor to objective #5.



Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
Practice Time: Complete the Sentences (5 min)	Instruct students to go through this task on their own.	For students who are struggling, include hints on the whiteboard 2 min into the activity, stating that Sentence #1 = difference, Sentence #2 – similarity, Sentence #3 – difference Include the answers on the board at the 5 min mark.	1) On the other hand 2) Likewise 3) in contrast	Enables students to practice the new language just reviewed.
Your Turn: Create Sentences with Partner (5 min)	Students in each pair decide which sentence (1 st or 2 nd) they'll be responsible for. Each write the sentence and the other student checks/provides feedback.	—	Open-ended; answers will vary	Provides students an opportunity to: 1. produce new language without any extra scaffolding. 2. share and receive peer feedback.
Reading 20-30 min				
Reading: The Gift of the Magi	Let students know that their individual hard copy of the 'The Gift of the Magi' is broken up into distinct chunks so that 'Student A' and 'Student B' (each pair assigns themselves)	Students are advised to have their dictionaries nearby if there is language that they're not certain about.	—	This story is included: 1.to enhance students' reading skills. 2.serve as a foundational



Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
	can take proper turns and have nearly equal reading time – You can note that Student A = 6 chunks and Student B = 5 chunks. Encourage students to individually underline key vocabulary and concepts, as well as note their feelings once they reach the ending.	You will also be available for students, checking in to see how they're progressing and answer any questions that may come up.		precursor to objectives #2-5.
If opting for the 2 x 60 min sessions, please note that this is approximately the 60-70 min mark of the lesson. If students haven't finished reading, they can continue in the next class.				
Reflection & Sharing Activate Section 40 min				
Reflection: Twist Ending & Your Own Story (Part I – 20 min)	Instruct students that in this activity, they will work individually to construct two paragraphs. The first will be about their thoughts on the story's ending. The second will be about one particular gift-exchange experience. Remind students that they have an option of writing out complete paragraphs or answer the questions directly	On the whiteboard, include key tips on the structure of a paragraph: 1. Intro sentence 2. Main idea #1 – Detail 3. Main idea #2- Detail 4. Concluding Sentence AND For those who decide to answer the Qs directly,	N/A - Open-ended; personal response	This is where students will have the chance to develop their writing skills by expounding on their individual perspective on the story and their own personal experience with a gift-exchange. <i>Objective focus:</i> #2. explain how the surprise ending of "The Gift of the



Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
	using complete sentences.	showcase an example of what is expected: <i>Do you think the characters handled the situation well? Yes, I genuinely think based on the circumstances of both being in the dark so to speak, James and Della handled themselves extremely well. The main reason is that they both accepted their gifts with grace, humility and a sense of humor.</i>		Magi” made me feel. #3.evaluate whether the characters in the story handled the situation well at the end. #4.compose a brief reflection about a meaningful gift-exchange experience from my own life.
Exchanging Stories: Sharing our Experiences (Part II – 10 min)	Explain to students that the next task is to reconvene with their partner and discuss their thoughts about the story’s ending and their own experiences related to gift exchanges. The latter can be general or specifically tied into what they wrote about in the first task. Remind students to actively listen to what their partner is sharing	Walk around the room and if you notice students who are shy to share or aren’t sure where to begin, feel comfortable to ask prompting questions or share your own experiences.	Open-ended; personal response	This task provides students with the opportunity to work on their speaking skills. This is also a foundational precursor to objective #5.



Lesson Section	Procedure	Scaffolding	Answers/Key Language	Rationale (optional)
	and to jot down notes tied to information that is either similar or different to your own thoughts or experiences.			
Exchanging Stories: Comparing Our Experiences (Part III – 10 min)	Explain to students how this task is going to tie in everything that they've learned and accomplished so far. Whether in writing or with their voices, ask that they work with their partner to create 3-5 sentences that show case the similarities and differences between their experiences and that of the stories by using the compare/contrast language.	Include one example sentence on the whiteboard to provide students with an idea what you're looking for: <i>Unlike my very positive and serendipitous gift-exchange experience last year with my mom, the Dillingham's gift exchange seemed a bit upsetting and discombobulating.</i>	Open-ended; should include target connectors (similarly, in contrast, unlike, on the other hand, likewise)	This activity enables students to practice their writing, listening and speaking skills. <i>Objective focus:</i> #5. compare and contrast my gift-giving experience with my partner's and with the story, using words like "similarly," "in contrast," and "unlike."



Credits & Attributions

Reading Text

"The Gift of the Magi" by O. Henry was originally published in 1905 and is in the public domain in the United States. This story is widely available through public libraries and public-domain literary archives. No changes were made to the original story content; the text has been divided into numbered reading chunks for the Paired Reading Chunks activity.

Images

The gift-box comparison illustrations ("My Set of Gifts" and "Your Set of Gifts") used in the Language Focus section were generated with AI assistance (Perplexity AI), based on content direction specified by the author. Final images reviewed and approved by Carmen Khoury.

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Worksheet Content & Lesson Design

Lesson objectives, activities, and teacher's guide procedures were developed by Carmen Khoury with AI assistance (Perplexity AI) for editorial review, instructional design feedback, and drafting support. Final content, wording, and instructional decisions reviewed and approved by Carmen Khoury.